

Mini essay

Title: Response to RFK Address

Defamiliarisation or dehabitualisation originating from Russian Formalism, refers to the process of “making strange”, like transformation of language or modes of expression in such a way that familiar, automated perceptions are rendered strange, thereby compelling the reader to re-perceive and reinterpret them. According to *Semiotics of Poetry* (Michael 1978), Michael describes this phenomenon as “ungrammaticality,” that is ungrammaticality is the mechanism of defamiliarisation or dehabitualisation. Moreover, Shklovsky (1917, pp.8-14) introduces defamiliarisation as a technique that disrupts habitual perception by presenting familiar phenomena in altered or defamiliarised forms. When it comes to the effect, defamiliarisation disrupts habitual perception and compels active interpretation, preventing automatic recognition. Through ungrammaticality, involving distortion and figurative turns that “defy logic”, it guides readers toward the totality of meaning. It also enables signs to be understood within broader structures, narratives, and discourses, rather than in isolation.

When it comes to analysis of Kennedy’s Speech, he uses various devices of defamiliarisation. In the sentence “this mindless menace of violence ... every one of our lives”, Kennedy uses metaphor to defamiliarize abstract concepts such as violence and social breakdown, violence is represented as something that “stains” the nation

(personification is also used). By this way, he makes violence visible and concrete rather than abstract and disrupts habitual perception of violence as “normal”, and it forces the audience to reinterpret violence as something abnormal, harmful, and in need of urgent attention. According to Ricoeur (2004, p. 4) discourse unleashes the power that violence has to re-describe reality. By linking violence to both “our land” and “every one of our lives,” Kennedy expands its impact from isolated incidents to a shared national condition. This compels the audience to recognize violence not as distant or normalized, but as something that collectively degrades society and implicates everyone. In doing so, the metaphor guides the audience toward a broader understanding of violence as a systemic and moral issue requiring urgent attention.

As for “A sniper is only a coward, not a hero” and the sentence in the same paragraph “uncontrollable mob is only the voice of madness, not the voice of the people.” Kennedy use binary to contrast two things respectively. One obvious sign is he uses the sentence pattern “only ... not”, he take the forms binaries: sniper and hero, mob and people. It breaks conventional associations, only violence not heroism, this positions violence within a broader social and discursive structure rather than as an isolated act. Another example about Kennedy use binary is in the sentence of “The victims of the violence are black and white ... famous and unknown.” By listing people with completely opposite characteristics, and telling the audience that they are all victims of violence, it is emphasized that violence affects a wide range of people and harms every group and individual in society.

As for “another kind of violence … This is the violence of institutions” and “slow destruction… hunger … homes without heat in the winter”, he uses the device of ungrammaticality to redefine “violence”. The most direct effect is defamiliarises the concept of violence, and compels active interpretation of violence. Then it expands it from physical acts (his color or his beliefs) to structural injustice (teach that he is a lesser man) , so that forces audience to see inequality as violence. This highlights that violence is not only visible and in a tangible form; it also exists in an intangible manner, this is a much greater and deeper form of injustice, for everyone, for society, and for the country.

Also, Kennedy repeatedly reworks the idea of violence in different forms, he uses the devices of repetition and variation. In the sentence “Some looks for scapegoats … can remove this sickness from our soul”, this repetition and variation reinforce a central invariant, namely that violence is self-perpetuating and systemic, rather than isolated.

Also, this pattern disrupts simple or habitual explanations (e.g. scapegoats or conspiracies) and compels the audience to reinterpret violence as part of a broader structural condition affecting society as a whole.

Kennedy’s speech employs metaphor, ungrammaticality, binary, repetition and other devices to disrupt habitual perception of violence. These devices guide the audience toward deeper levels of meaning and situate violence within broader social and discursive structures, thereby intensifying interpretation and moral awareness.

References:

Ricoeur, P., 2004. *The rule of metaphor: The creation of meaning in language*. Routledge.

Riffaterre, M., 1978. *Semiotics of poetry*. Indiana University Press.

Shklovsky, V., 1917. Art as technique. *Literary theory: An anthology*, 3(3), pp.3-4.